

ANNA NAGAR

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Smart tech to help pedestrians



New signal-controlled pedestrian crossings featuring push-button technology have been introduced at key locations in Chennai, including Anna Nagar, to enhance safety by allowing pedestrians to initiate a crossing phase.

PHOTO: VELANKANNI RAJ B

'Relay the carriageway at Villivakkam subway'

M. SENTHIL

The carriageway at the Villivakkam vehicular subway is uneven because of a succession of patchworks carried out over the years, the last one

coming up a year ago.

The subway was inaugurated a decade-and-a-half ago, and since then, it has not been treated to a thoroughgoing road-relaying work. It has been one patchwork after another. The uneven surface of the carriageway proves risky for motorists at night as the subway is not sufficiently lit.

M. Senthil is a resident of Villivakkam

Stray dogs 'sully' Thangal park

N. HARIKRISHNAN



Conservancy workers clean the Thangal park in Ambattur regularly. However, a good number of stray dogs defecate across the facility. Visitors to the park need to watch their steps. Instead of a compound wall, the park is fenced by iron grills and therefore dogs manage to enter the park through the gaps (as the image shows) in these grills. Greater Chennai Corporation should address this issue.

N. Harikrishnan is a resident of Ambattur

'Frequency of small bus service S42 is poor'

S. AMIRTHALAKSHMI

The frequency of the small bus service S42 connecting Korattur and Maduravoyal is poor, specially during peak hours.

Commuters have to wait close to an hour-and-a-half between eight and 10 in the morning and between five and eight in the evening. This results in overcrowding and commuters resort to foot-board travel endangering their lives.

This route witnesses good patronage, therefore the frequency should be increased. Metropolitan Transport Corporation should add a few more buses to the S42 route.

S. Amirthalakshmi is a resident of Padi

'Safety measures lacking at SWD construction site'

D. RADHAKRISHNAN

Greater Chennai Corporation is currently carrying out stormwater drain construction work at Medawakkam Tank Road in Kilpauk. But safety measures are lacking at the construction site. The image, taken on February 20, 2026, show workers without helmets and ankle boots. And the number of barricades along the site is not adequate.

Besides, planning and coordination in execution of the work leaves a lot to be desired.

Power supply was disrupted on January 31 and February 12. The power that went off around 11 at night was restored



at 10 in the morning. Later, we learnt that officials of Greater Chennai Corporation and electricity department were not present at the site. This is a re-

sult of poor planning and coordination among the departments.

D. Radhakrishnan is a resident of Kilpauk

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'Upkeep of park at Paruthipattu lake is poor'

ANU NANDHANA. M

The park at Paruthipattu lake in Avadi is poorly maintained. Developed at a cost of ₹28.16 crore, the 87-acre park was opened to the public in 2019.

One of the major recreational facilities in the locality, the park has a three-km walking track, open-air

theatre, children's play area, boating facility, and a library. It witnesses a good number of visitors.

However, regular users find the facility to be in a state of neglect.

Until a few years ago, a good number of sanitation workers were engaged for the upkeep of the park. But now, only a couple of workers are deployed, and they reportedly clean only the entrance

area, while the walking track and interior areas remain neglected.

Another issue is stray dogs entering the park. They defecate at the facility and there have been a few instances of dogs chasing the visitors.

Complaints to the Avadi Municipal Corporation have been in vain.

Anu Nandhana. M is a resident of Avadi.



The park at Paruthipattu lake in Avadi. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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Sewage in water pipes, say Villivakkam residents

Poorly executed water pipe-laying work by CMWSSB is causing the contamination, they allege

R. KUMAR

The ongoing water pipe-laying work, carried out by the Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply & Sewerage Board, at South Jagganathan Nagar in Villivakkam, is testing the patience of residents. The work has damaged sewage drains and existing water pipes resulting in sewage overflow on the roads and sewage contamination in water supplied through the existing pipes.

Residents ended up cleaning their sumps and overhead water tanks a number of times in less than a month.

Unless CMWSSB takes corrective measures, cleaning the tanks will be a futile exercise, entailing a recurrent expense. Many residents have therefore resorted to buying water from private suppliers.

It may be noted that without addressing the root cause for the sewage leakage, the pits on the roads have been covered as a quick-fix to arrest sewage overflow. Sewage overflow is therefore likely to crop up again.



Besides, electricity cables also got damaged causing frequent disruptions in power supply. These cables are also dangerously exposed raising the risk of untoward incidents. All these speak of poor planning and coordination in the execution of the work.

R. Kumar is a resident of Villivakkam



CMWSSB's pipe-laying site on Third Main Road at South Jagganathan Nagar in Villivakkam. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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'This electricity box poses a risk'



N. CHITTIBABU

The images, taken on February 28, 2026, show an electricity box at Jai Nagar 13th Street in Arumbakkam in a precarious state. It is supported by a wooden plank and the wires are exposed.

This has been the status of the junction box for the past four months. Complaints to Tamil Nadu Generation & Distribution Corporation Limited have gone in vain.

N. ChittiBabu is a resident of Arumbakkam

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The bus termini at MKB Nagar and (below) KKD Nagar.

Commuters seek better services from MKB Nagar bus terminus

L. KANTHIMATHI

The bus termini at KKD Nagar and MKB Nagar (better known as Mullai Nagar) were reopened recently after a redevelopment work carried out by the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority. Both the facilities which are decades-old wear a new look. They have been provided with a tensile roof, bays for buses, and boards listing the services operated from the terminus along with time. Further, officials have been provided with



separate rooms and dining halls. At KKD Nagar terminus, dedicated restrooms have been provided for the differently-abled commuters. Both the termini were known

heavy waterlogging in case of rains and that will not be the case any more, say MTC officials. Regular commuters welcome the new look of the termini however they find the lack of counters to issue season tickets as a drawback.

Both the bus termini are spacious but lack this basic facility, say commuters. At MKB Nagar, commuters raised the issue of poor frequency of buses operated from the terminus. "There are services to Vadapalani and Broadway, and there are services to Kilambakkam operated via two different routes: one via GST Road and the other via Perungalathur - Puzhal Bypass. But only services to Koyambedu are frequent and the others are poor. We hardly find those buses and don't even wait for them," says a regular commuter.

'Route some buses through Perambur church stopover'

K.P. NARENDRAKUMAR

Traffic congestion near the Perambur railway station (where a major bus stand is located) is getting worse by the day. One would expect vehicular traffic movement to be thrown out of kilter where a major infrastructural work is under way. On this section, Metro rail work is in progress, but that does not explain all of the chaos prevalent there.

If some of the bus-commuting population is diverted from this Railway station bus stand, and the buses along with them, the congestion could ease up. If some of the buses headed to the Perambur bus terminus that touch the Railway station bus stand are diverted to the Perambur church bus stand, there could be a two-fold benefit. Besides reducing the congestion, it would offer commuters in Perambur West better connectivity, as the Perambur church bus stand is closer to them.



PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Such a move would ensure an equitable distribution of bus route numbers between Perambur East and West.

In addition, with fewer buses

touching Perambur railway station bus stand, pedestrians' movement will become easier.

(K P Narendrakumar is a resident of Thiru-Vi-Ka Nagar)

Ideas to deal with a commuting crisis



Commuters at Tambaram railway station.
PHOTO: B. VELANKANNI RAJ

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Many groups have urged the Chennai Division of the Southern Railway to swiftly address disruptions to the suburban train services on account of the redevelopment work at Chennai Egmore railway station.

As part of re-construction of suburban train platforms 10 and 11 and foundation work for a new roof over the platforms, train services have been disrupted since February 20.

In a letter to the Southern Railway, T. Nagar Residents' Welfare Association has asked whether Egmore station can be skipped and the usual services operated.

It has urged railway authorities to reassess the present operational plan and evolve alternative arrangements that protect the interests of the larger commuting public while redevelopment works continue.

V. Rama Rao, director, Traffic and Transportation Forum, has written to Ashwini Vaishnaw, Union Minister for Railways, stating that the State's fleet of buses is not enough to meet the regular demand of commuters, and therefore the disruption in train services cannot be borne. The railway ministry should hire many buses on a temporary basis and operate them at a fare of ₹ 10 till the work is completed, says Rama Rao.

At present, special buses from Tambaram to Chennai Beach and vice versa run during rush hour in the morning and evening. "There should be coordination among the railway, Chennai Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority, the Metropolitan Transport Corporation and Chennai Metro Rail to ensure seamless commuter support during the transition period.

P. Sathyanarayanan, social activist and a long-time resident of Guindy, is of the opinion that long-distance trains operated from Chennai Egmore should be operated from Tambaram till the redevelopment work at the suburban train platforms gets completed.

"The Vande Bharat Express running from Egmore to Nagercoil should run from Egmore, as it departs at 5 a.m., and in the return direction reaches Egmore at 23.05 p.m.," says Sathyanarayanan.

At present, shuttle services are operated between Chennai Beach and Egmore, and from Egmore to Tambaram and Chengalpattu on express train line till Chetpet railway station, where it joins the suburban line.

"If long-distance trains are operated from Tambaram, two trains, Egmore to Tambaram and Chengalpattu, and from Chengalpattu and Tambaram to Egmore, the trains can be operated. This move will not increase commuters' traffic waiting for trains. This move will help save time and reduce crowding in other public transport, he pointed out.

"For example, if a commuter has to go from Egmore to Guindy, has to take a bus to Anna Salai and board another to Guindy. The other option is to board a metro train at Egmore, de-train at Alandur, interchange, and entrain the line (train) towards WIMCO Nagar," he added.

The air conditioners on Metro trains are ineffective due to the crowd.

Educating the special educators

Over the last week, practitioners from 15 institutions in Chennai went through an in-person upskilling training programme conducted by the faculty of Portobello Institute in Ireland; Chennai Volunteers made this exercise possible



Representational picture only.

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

When Lakshmi Menon and her team members started to solve the 'Zin Monument' activity based on clues given to them, they found it an uphill task. The problem-solving exercise required them to determine the day of the week the monument was completed. They found themselves having to do three things simultaneously: look at the problem keenly; communicate it in the best possible way and collaborate intensely as they went about solving it.

More than 30 special educators like Lakshmi, representing WeCAN, got a ringside view of a variety of problem-solving strategies they could apply in their classroom, thanks to an immersive workshop organised by Chennai Volunteers in partnership with Portobello Institute in Ireland.

'Celebrating Neurodiversity 2.0', as the workshop was called, was aimed at upskilling special educators, therapists, trainers working with children and young people with Autism Spectrum Disorder and related developmental and behavioural challenges.



Rinku Mecheri (extreme left) with the team from Portobello Institute and some of the participants

In a press release, Rinku Mecheri, founder, Chennai Volunteers, says that the programme is a follow-up to last year's initiative, based on an in-depth assessment of the unique needs of special children in underserved communities, in and around Chennai.

The initiative is aimed at strengthening non-profits working in the field of special education so that so they can work more effectively with their students and beneficiaries.

In this certified programme, the content and presentations are shared with all, and each team cascades the knowledge to their colleagues in the respective organisation, says Rinku. This in-person programme would be followed by online sessions.

A team of six faculty led by Denise Flood, Executive Dean of Portobello Institute, conducted

various sessions including one on impact of physical education, creative arts and music therapy in the classroom.

The team from Portobello Institute also visited some of the schools or homes to engage with the students.

Rinku says Chennai Volunteers is proud to host this programme that helps the special needs educators and therapists by building their skills, strengthening inclusion and creating impact.

"Volunteers can bring about transformative change through capacity building and skill training, and we want more individuals and organisations to come forward and benefit," she adds.

One can reach out to Chennai Volunteers at contactus@chennaivolunteers.org or call 9840182299.

'Government support needed to further special education'

LIFFY THOMAS

Denise Flood, Executive Dean at Portobello Institute in Dublin, Ireland, led a six-member team that was in Chennai for a week-long programme for special educators initiated by Chennai Volunteers. In an interaction with *The Hindu Downtown*, Denise talks about the importance of flexible courses in Special Needs Assisting and the role of government in furthering the reach of inclusive education.

* What is the importance of this five-day programme?

Education is evolving globally, particularly in how we support learners with intellectual and developmental disabilities. As our understanding of diverse learning profiles grows, educators must continually update their skills to respond effectively to emerging classroom needs.

This five-day programme provides an opportunity for practitioners to refresh their knowledge, engage with current research and collaborate with peers to develop practical, inclusive strategies. The focus is on empowering educators to create learning environments where children with additional needs can participate fully and thrive alongside their peers.

* Special schools and NGOs in India encourage parents of children with special needs to become special educators. What do you have to say about this trend?

It is encouraging to see schools and centres supporting parents seeking to pursue training in special education. Parents bring invaluable lived experience and insight into their child's strengths and needs.

When equipped with professional training, they can rein-

force learning across home and school environments, supporting language development, social skills and independence in a consistent and meaningful way.

* Portobello Institute offers a number of flexible programmes in Special Needs Assisting, why are such programmes necessary?

Many professionals seek opportunities to upskill while continuing to work, which is why our programmes are designed with flexible delivery options. This accessibility helps broaden participation and strengthens the inclusive education workforce.

There is increasing demand for inclusive practices across all levels of education, beginning in early years settings. Professional training ensures that practition-

Parents bring invaluable lived experience and insight into their child's strengths and needs

ers are equipped with evidence-based approaches, practical skills and the confidence to support diverse learners effectively.

* What can India learn from Dublin?

In Ireland, there has been significant investment in supporting students who wish to pursue qualifications in special education. Government funding models have helped make these programmes more accessible encouraging practitioners to return to education and enhance their qualifications.

We have seen strong engagement in our own programmes, with over 200 practitioners upskilling last academic year reflecting a clear commitment within the sector to continuous professional development.

Even as Wels in Austria hosted World Sustainable Energy Days 2026 from February 24 to 27, *The Hindu Downtown* picked the brains of quiet influencers Bhuvana Raj and Saravanan Palanichami whose philosophy of sustainable energy use in their home settings is rubbing off on neighbours and friends

Infectious energy



Saravanan Palanichami and Bhuvana Raj with their respective solar installations. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

There is a pleasant monotony to how Bhuvana Raj's electricity bill reads for most part of the year. For nearly ten months annually, every billing cycle, the needle stays at zero (discounting the small regular fee).

A sustainability practitioner and zero waste consultant, Bhuvana installed a rooftop solar system at her home in Thalambur, off OMR, in 2018, when residential solar adoption in Chennai Metropolitan Area was yet to shine brightly.

Although the initial estimate suggested a 2 kW system would suffice, the family chose to plan ahead. "The estimate given for our house was 2 kW. But we decided to add one more unit, thinking that our consumption would increase in the future and we should be able to offset that as well. So we went in for a 3 kW system in 2018 itself," she says. The system cost about ₹1.5 lakh after subsidy.

"I am not exactly sure when it broke even, but I think it was

around four years after installation," she adds.

Only during peak summer, when air conditioner use increases, does the family pay anything at all. "Only during April and May, when consumption increases because of AC usage, do we pay an amount for consumption." And this amount is still one of ridiculously small numbers.

"Recently, they started charging a network fee of around ₹300 plus, so that is the only regular fee we are paying now," she explains. "Not worrying about electricity bills, especially when others pay ₹10,000 or ₹12,000 during summer, is very reassuring," she says.

Though her overall experience is pleasant, Bhuvana would like to see some wrinkles ironed out, not on her end, but Tangedco's.

"When we generate more energy than we use, it goes back to the grid, but Tangedco does not pay us for that surplus. Besides, there is no dashboard to show how many unused units we are giving back," she says.

She adds that people often have doubts when choosing systems. Off

grid systems use batteries and can function during outages. Systems connected to the grid are more economical but shut down during power cuts for safety reasons. "Our area gets flooded during monsoons, and sometimes power cuts continue for days. In such situations, off grid systems help. But when we did the math, on grid made more sense economically in the long run," she says.

In her gated villa community of around 330 houses, rooftop solar adoption has steadily increased. "Around 30 to 40 per cent have gone solar. We are not actively promoting it, but people are installing it on their own after understanding the benefits" she says.

For Bhuvana, the decision goes beyond savings. "I see solar not just as a cost saving option but also as a responsible choice for the future. In our country, we have abundant sunlight almost throughout the year," she says.

She also believes more attention must be paid to what happens later. "After 20 or 30 years, what happens to these panels? How will they be recycled? These are areas

where more research is needed," she says, adding that policy and research must evolve alongside adoption.

A smart move

A software engineer based in Kovilambakkam, Saravanan Palanichami installed his first solar system 13 years ago, at the time he built his house. "The original idea was to ensure uninterrupted power supply," he says. Instead of depending entirely on an inverter connected to the grid, he chose a 1.4 kilowatt off grid system with batteries that could function like a UPS.

For years, that system powered the essentials – fans, refrigerator, televisions, computers and lights. During the day, solar panels charged the batteries. At night, the stored energy ran the house until early morning. When Cyclone Vardah struck Chennai and power cuts lasted for days, his decision proved wise. "During major storms in Chennai, including Cyclone Vardah, when there were week long power cuts, this system proved extremely useful," he recalls.

But the real turning point came recently, with the purchase of an electric vehicle.

"Recently, we bought an electric vehicle. We realised that if the car had to be truly zero emission, the energy used to charge it should also come from renewable sources," he says. That realisation prompted the installation of an additional 6 kilowatt on grid solar system.

Unlike the battery backed setup, the on grid system operates independently of household wiring. "The on grid system is not connected to any of my appliances, including the EV. It supplies power back to the grid through the power lines," he explains. Through net metering, electricity generated during the day is exported to the grid.

His advice to EV owners: "If you have an on grid system, you are already prepared. Try to charge your EV during the day to maximise the use of your generated power. If you have to charge at night, your solar installation will still reduce your overall electricity cost, but you will not be reducing the load on the grid at that time."

From Koyambedu to *Paris*

Syed Akram Javeed was recently conferred the Chief Minister's State Sports Award for 2025-26; he has been officiating tennis tournaments for many years

K. KEERTHIVASAN

Syed Akram Javeed, an International Tennis Federation Bronze badge Umpire from Chennai, was recently conferred with the Chief Minister's State Sports Award for 2025-26 by the Government of Tamil Nadu. The award, presented by the Deputy Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, Udhayanidhi Stalin was received on his behalf by Akram's father Syed Karimullah.

Akram has been among the widely travelled umpires in India after having received the White badge in 2017 and Bronze badge in 2024.

The 32-year-old has officiated in Olympics (2024 - Paris), Asian Games (2023 - Hangzhou) and Grand Slams such as Australian Open (2024, 2025 and 2026), French Open (2023, 2025 and selected for 2026) and Wimbledon (2018, 2023 and 2024), and many Association of Tennis Professionals (ATP), Women Tennis Association (WTA) Tour and ATP Challenger events. In fact, he made his Davis Cup debut in February this year by officiating the Indonesia versus Togo match.

"Receiving the Tamil Nadu Government State Award for Officiating is an incredibly humbling and emotional moment for me. To be recognised by the Govern-

ment of Tamil Nadu, the state where I was born and brought up, makes this honour deeply personal and meaningful. Officiating is often a quiet profession—one that demands integrity, composure, and consistency behind the scenes. To have those years of dedication acknowledged at the state level is both gratifying and motivating. This award is not just a recognition of my journey, but also of the mentors, colleagues, and players who have shaped me along the way," said Akram, a resident of Koyambedu.

Having begun his career in tennis officiating in 2014 following four years of experience in tournament operations at the Chennai Open, Akram has indeed come a long way.



Kids slug it out in sports arena



The sixth sports meet of Dayasadan Agarwal Vidyalaya (DSAV) was recently held with lively participation of students from pre-KG to UKG.

P. S. Aravind Raj, the centre director of Euro Kids, Koyambedu, was the chief guest. The marchpast by the children was

a charming show of teamwork, self-assurance and discipline.

The highlight of the day was the 50-metre races and group games, which filled the field with excitement and cheers. A special parent event boosted the spirit of participation.

Remembering *Subramania Bharati*

Shriram Bharathi Kalai Ilakkiya Kazhagam recently observed the 144th birth anniversary of freedom fighter and poet Subramania Bharathi at Krishna Gana Sabha, T. Nagar. Three eminent scholars promot-

ing Bharathi's work across the globe, M. Thyagarajan, Kalaimamani Keezhambur Sankara Subramanian, and V.G. Booma, were felicitated on the occasion with cash awards and citations.

Ku. Gnanasambanthan, emeritus, professor Thiagarajar College, Madu-

rai, spoke on 'Vetri Mael Vetri'.

Justice R. Suresh Kumar, Madras High Court, released a book, 'Avvaiyin Senthamizh Puthaiyal.'

A copy of the book was distributed to all attendees of the event.

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Student initiates career guidance programme in Vyasarpadi

Sanju Vikasini D of Madras School of Social Work decided to educate people in the locality about job openings in the government sector



During the workshop.

A career guidance programme titled "What Next? Your Path to Government Careers" was organised on February 26 by the PG Department of Social Work (SF), Madras School of Social Work, in collaboration with Oasis India, in Vyasarpadi.

The programme was organised by Sanju Vikasini D, a student of the Post Graduate Department of Social Work (SF), Madras School of Social Work, as part of her field-work with Oasis India, said a release. During her field engagement, she found that many students, unemployed graduates, and youth in the community—particularly those from socially and economically vul-

nerable backgrounds—lacked access to reliable information and guidance regarding career in the government sector.

The session was facilitated by G. Sriram, Founder and Director of Kalam IAS Academy, who spoke about the importance of government employment as a means of achieving financial security, dignity, and long-term stability. He provided clarity on career pathways and motivated participants to pursue their goals with determination and confidence.

The programme witnessed enthusiastic participation from nearly 100 members of the Vyasarpadi community, including unemployed graduates and homemakers.

One-minute video contest for students

The Public Relations Society of India (PRSI), Chennai Chapter, in association with Coromandel International Limited, invites nominations for a state-level One-Minute Public Service Announcement (PSA) Video Contest on the theme "Save Food, Save Future."

The contest aims to inspire young filmmakers to use visual storytelling to promote food conservation and highlight the value of every grain produced through farmers' hard work. Open to college students, this initiative encourages youth participation in spreading awareness about responsible consumption and sustainability through impactful short-format cinema, said a release.

The contest will focus on the theme "Save Food, Save Future" and the video

must be produced in Tamil with a duration of exactly one minute. The last date for submission is April 14, 2026.

Winners will be awarded attractive cash prizes, with ₹25,000 for the first prize, ₹15,000 for the second prize, and ₹10,000 for the third prize.

The competition is open to college students between the ages of 17 and 24 who are studying in Tamil Nadu or Puducherry.

Entries will be evaluated by a panel of experts based on script and storytelling, direction, cinematography, production quality, and background music.

For further details, please contact: N. Raja, Secretary, Public Relations Society of India - Chennai Chapter, Mobile: 63838 53001

Exnora gets excavators for rejuvenating waterbodies

Mobis India Foundation handed over five Hyundai R140 excavator machines to ExNoRa International Foundation (EIF) in a function held at Secretariat recently.

The handover took place in the presence of Chief Minister M.K. Stalin.

The machines will be used and given by the EIF on a rent-free basis for desilting, restoring, and maintaining water bodies and waterways in the districts of Tiruvallur, Tirupattur, Tiruvallur, Kanchipuram, and Vellore, said a release.

Senior officials from Mobis India who attended the event included Park Ki Chul, Managing Director; Ju Seong Kyu, General Manager; Huh Min Ho, Deputy General Manager; Narasimhan, HOD CSR Department; and Infant Roshina, CSR Department. S.Senthur Pari, President, Subramanian and Mohana Sundaram trustees of ExNoRa International Foundation, received the excavators.

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